B1 Speaking

Making polite requests

Ask for things politely in shops, at work and with friends, and know which form fits each situation.

In English, how you ask matters as much as what you ask. A direct command can sound rude even when you do not mean it. Longer, softer questions sound more polite.

Form	How polite	Example
Can you...?	Friendly, for people you know	*Can you pass the salt?*
Could you...?	Polite, for most situations	*Could you send me the file?*
Would you mind + -ing?	Very polite	*Would you mind closing the window?*
Could I / May I...?	Asking for permission	*Could I borrow your pen? May I come in?*
I'd like... / Could I have...?	Ordering in a shop or café	*I'd like a coffee, please. Could I have the bill?*

Answering *Would you mind...?* *No, not at all* means "yes, I'll do it", because you are saying you do not mind.

Common mistake. Translating a direct Arabic request word for word: *Give me a coffee* sounds rude in English. Say *Could I have a coffee, please?* And remember *please* and *thank you* even with friends.

Practice

Make each request more polite.

1. (to a waiter) Bring me the menu.
2. (to your manager) Check my report.

3. (to a stranger on a train) Move your bag.
4. (to a teacher) I want to leave early.
5. (to a friend) Lend me 10 dollars.
6. Someone asks "Would you mind waiting a moment?" You are happy to wait. What do you say?

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Could I have the menu, please?
2. Could you check my report, please? / Would you mind checking my report?
3. Would you mind moving your bag, please?
4. Could I leave early today, please? / May I leave early?
5. Can you lend me 10 dollars?
6. No, not at all. / No problem.